Caregiver Survey: Key Findings

SPASD Weighted Grades Work Group · Oct 22, 2026 · @Zack Mark

The short version

531 caregivers answered in the first week, and 70% support weighted grades. The biggest risk for the plan is timing, not whether to weight.

1. **Support is strong and even.** 70% rated it a 4 or 5. Support was about the same at West (68%) and East (73%).
2. **Timing splits by family.** Caregivers of current high schoolers want it applied now, 69% to 31%. Families with only younger kids want to start next year, 74% to 26%. Our Oct 20 plan starts with next year's freshmen, so the families most invested are the ones it leaves out.
3. **Rigor is the reason.** Supporters say over and over that harder classes should count more. AP is the clear favorite to weight (85%).
4. **Opponents worry about fairness and simplicity.** The top reasons: all classes have value, keep the 4.0 simple, and students without access to AP fall behind.
5. **Families want it explained.** 72% asked for a detailed written explanation. Undecided caregivers mostly said they need more information, not that they disagree.

Who answered

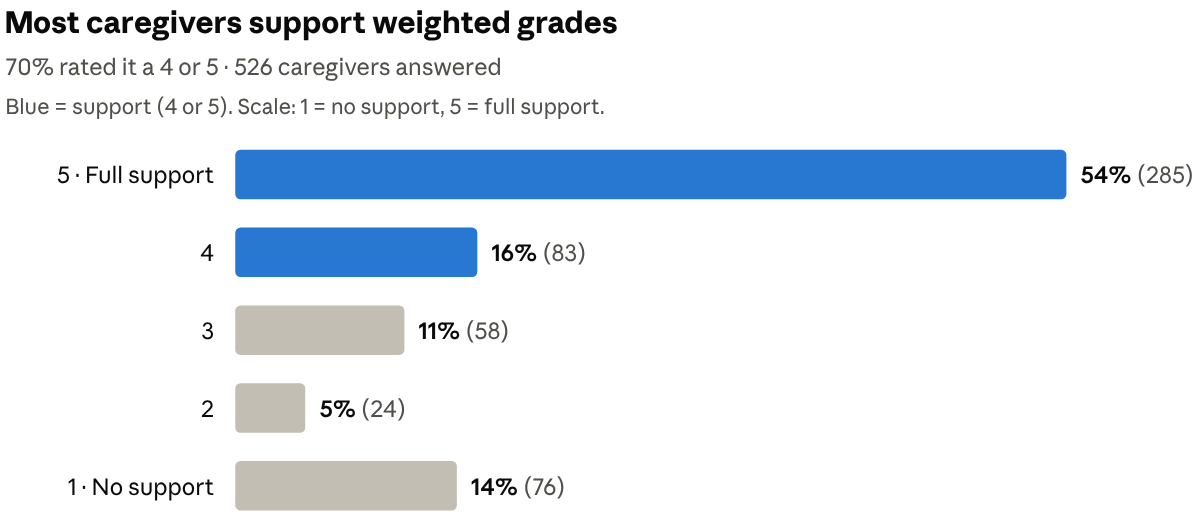
531 responses came in from Oct 16 to Oct 22, and 62% arrived on the first day (328).

Group	Responses
Families with a current high schooler (grades 9–12)	320
Families with only K–8 students	204
Sun Prairie West families	263
Sun Prairie East families	245
Other or no school listed (virtual, Prairie Phoenix, blank)	23

Families could list more than one grade, so the rows overlap. The East and West counts are close, so neither school's families dominate the results.

Support for weighted grades

70% of caregivers support weighted grades, and only 19% oppose them.



Caregiver survey PDF export · 526 ratings, Oct 16–22, 2026

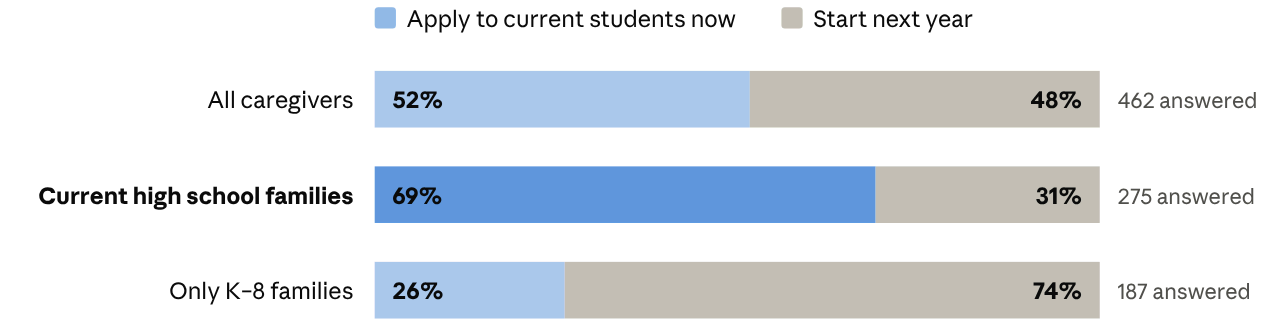
Support barely changes by group: 68% at West, 73% at East, and 70% for families both with and without a current high schooler. Opposition is strong among the few who hold it: most opponents chose 1, not 2.

When it should start

Overall it's close to a tie, but the split by family is large: families with a current high schooler want it now, and families with younger kids want to wait.

Families of current high schoolers want it applied now

When should weighted grades start? Share of each group that answered



Work group plan (Oct 20): start with next year's freshmen. Blanks and unreadable answers left out.

Caregiver survey PDF export · 462 clear timing answers, Oct 16–22, 2026

Each group mostly picked the option that helps their own child. That's normal, but it means the families with the most at stake are the ones our plan leaves out. 61 caregivers skipped this question, mostly people who oppose weighting entirely.

Which classes, and why

AP is the clear favorite: 85% want AP weighted. That matches our recommendation.

Question	Top answers (share of all 531)
Classes to weight	AP 85% · dual enrollment 46% · STEM Academy 17%
Factors they weighed	Rigor 75% · college credit 57% · time commitment 56%
How they want to learn about it	Detailed written explanation 72% · information sessions 40%

The course list in our export is cut off, so options listed after STEM (including capstones) can't be counted. The full spreadsheet would fix that. Rigor beating college credit supports our choice to weight capstones, not only classes that earn credit.

What families wrote

388 caregivers explained their rating. Supporters mostly talk about effort, while opponents talk about fairness. Quotes are anonymous and copied as written.

Group	Main themes	In their words
Support (4–5), 276 explained	Harder classes should count more (about half name rigor, effort or AP). Act 95 and direct admit. Other districts already do it. The current system discourages AP.	"Harder schedules should be rewarded." · "Extra incentive to take advanced classes" · "This is long overdue!"
Unsure (3), 41 explained	Need more information. Want the pros, cons and reasoning first.	"Need more information. Pros and cons." · "Hate to pressure students"
Oppose (1–2), 70 explained	All classes have equal value. Keep the 4.0 simple. Equity for students without AP access. Stress. Colleges recalculate GPA anyway.	"Every class should have equal importance." · "The scale stops at 4 for a reason." · "It's not equitable"

A warning sign about the survey itself. A few opponents said it reads as if the decision is already made. The timing question had no "don't adopt it" option, and 44 caregivers who rated it a 1 skipped that question. The communication package should show that feedback can still change the plan.

Questions families want answered

147 caregivers left a comment or question. These five came up most and belong in the communication package's FAQ.

1. **Does it apply to my student, and when does it start?** This was the most common question (about 23 comments), often about a current junior or senior. Some asked whether GPAs would be recalculated going back.
2. **How does it affect Act 95 and college admissions?** Families asked how it ties to the Wisconsin guarantee and whether colleges use the weighted GPA.

3. **Which classes count?** People asked about audition music classes, electives, dual credit and capstones. Some said college credit alone shouldn't earn a weight.
4. **Is it fair to students without access?** Families asked whether every student can get into weighted classes.
5. **Why change now, and is it already decided?** A few wanted the reasons behind the change and proof the survey matters.

Recommendations for the work group

Next work group meeting. Decide how we answer families of current high schoolers before anything goes public.

- Option A: keep "next year's freshmen only" and give a short, honest reason, for example that current students chose classes under the old rules and changing them mid-course isn't fair.
- Option B: weight classes taken from 2027–28 on for every student, without recalculating past grades. This gives current students something without rewriting old transcripts.
- Either way, say plainly that past grades won't be recalculated. Families asked about this.

One-page communication package. Lead with the reason (rigor), list exactly which classes count, and add a five-question FAQ built from the section above. 72% asked for a written explanation, so the written piece matters more than events.

Nov 2 and Nov 9 (Board). Bring three numbers: 70% caregiver support, 78% of students choosing a weighted option in the Act 95 survey, and the 69% to 31% timing split. Name the split ourselves rather than letting Board members hear it first from parents.

Address equity directly. Opponents' strongest point is access. Show how students get into AP and capstone classes and what support exists, so weighting doesn't look like a reward only for students who already have access.

Method and limits

- Source: the PDF export of the caregiver survey responses (531 rows, Oct 16–22). Percentages are of all 531 unless a question's own count is given.
- The survey is self-selected, so it shows who chose to answer, not every family in the district.

- The PDF cuts long answers off after about 45 characters. Comment themes are based on those first words, so treat the theme counts as rough. The full spreadsheet would give exact counts.
- Student comparison figures come from the Dec 2025 – Jan 2026 Act 95 student survey (903 responses).
- Names and emails that some families left for follow-up are not included here.